

Team Rules & Working Agreement

This document lays out how we're going to work together as a team. It covers communication, responsibilities, and the general expectations we're all agreeing to uphold throughout the project. Our goal is to create a professional, respectful, and collaborative engineering environment that reflects real-world software development practices while helping every team member grow technically and professionally.

Team Goals

Our shared goal is to strengthen our software engineering knowledge while improving communication, team management, system design, and collaborative problem-solving skills. Through this project, we want to gain hands-on experience working in an environment that mirrors real engineering workflows, including ownership, deadlines, iteration, and long-term maintainability. By developing these skills together, we become stronger engineers individually and as a team, better preparing ourselves for industry-level collaboration and future technical opportunities.

Team Values

We operate with respect, accountability, and honesty. Everyone comes in with a different background and different strengths, and that's an asset, not a problem. Equal effort is a hard expectation, not a suggestion. If someone is struggling, we help them through teaching, feedback, or just being available. We keep things professional but also actually supportive.

Communication Standards

All team communication happens on Slack. Discussions, decisions, blockers, and updates should live there so nothing gets lost in side conversations. Keep notifications on and have it on your phone if possible. If something is blocking you or you can't make a commitment, say so early, not the night before. General stuff goes in the main channel; personal concerns can start as a DM.

Meetings and Attendance

We meet **Tuesdays at 8:30 PM on Zoom**. Show up on time and come prepared with what you've done, what you're stuck on, and what's next. If you can't make it, let the team know ahead of time, don't just ghost. The team can move forward without you if needed, but you're responsible for reading the notes and catching up on anything assigned to you. We'll rotate note-taking so it doesn't fall on the same person every week.

Roles and Accountability

Each team member will be assigned clear responsibilities, ownership areas, and deadlines to reduce confusion and ensure accountability. These responsibilities may include technical implementation, documentation, testing, deployment, meeting notes, or milestone coordination depending on the project

phase. While ownership should remain clear, our roles should also remain flexible enough to accommodate absences, changing workloads, and evolving project needs. Progress and ownership should always remain visible through Slack updates, task boards, and milestone check-ins.

Contribution Expectations

Fair and equal contribution is a core rule of this team. Every member is expected to actively participate, complete assigned work on time, communicate progress honestly, and contribute meaningfully to both technical and logistical tasks. We will use milestone progress, meeting participation, visible task ownership, and regular updates to ensure contributions remain balanced. If someone starts falling behind, we address it directly and right away, not two weeks later when it's already a crisis.

Resolving Weaknesses and Conflict

We recognize that challenges may arise, including differences in technical familiarity, communication styles, scheduling conflicts, or uncertainty around ownership. These issues must be addressed quickly and professionally. Our first step will always be respectful one-on-one communication to resolve the issue directly. If the issue continues, it should be escalated to team leadership, then to the TA, and finally to the professor if necessary. General concerns that affect the whole team should be discussed openly in Slack so that alignment is maintained.

Workflow and Success Standards

We're working in milestones with clear deadlines and defined ownership at each stage. Success will be measured not only by the quality of the final deliverable, but also by our ability to consistently hit milestones, maintain strong communication, ensure fair contribution, and resolve blockers efficiently. The process matters just as much as the outcome, and we want our workflow to reflect the standards of a real engineering team.

Final Commitment

By agreeing to these rules, every team member commits to professionalism, accountability, communication, and equal effort throughout the project lifecycle. Our goal is not simply to complete the assignment, but to build something meaningful while operating as a disciplined and supportive software engineering team.

Individual Acknowledgement

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